

C-10 Electrical Contractor — Licensing Checklist

California Contractors State License Board (CSLB) · pathtotrades.com · Updated March 2026

Timeline	Total Cost	Bond Required	Workers' Comp
4–12 months	\$900–\$2,000+	\$25,000	MANDATORY (no exemption)

Step 1: Verify 4 Years Experience

Before applying · \$0

- Certification of Work Experience form (supervisor-signed)
- W-2s, pay stubs, or tax returns (4 years)
- Education transcripts (if substituting up to 3 years)

Tip: Experience verification is the #1 delay reason.

Step 2: Submit CSLB Application

1 day + 8–12 week wait · \$450

- Completed CSLB application for C-10 classification
- Experience certification forms attached
- \$450 fee — check or money order (non-refundable)

Tip: CSLB is backlogged 8–12 weeks. Do not quit your job until license # is in hand.

Step 3: Fingerprinting (Live Scan)

1 day · \$49–\$80

- Government photo ID
- CSLB Live Scan request form

Tip: Do this while app processes — runs in parallel.

Step 4: Prepare for & Pass 2 Exams

1–3 months · \$150–\$500

- **KEY STEP — 50% fail without prep, 90%+ pass with a course**
- Prep course enrollment or self-study materials
- Law & Business: 115 Qs, 3.5 hrs, closed-book, 72% to pass
- C-10 Trade: 100 Qs, 3.5 hrs, closed-book, 72% to pass

Tip: Law & Business: study mechanics liens, payroll taxes, contract law — NOT trade codes.

Step 5: Complete Asbestos Open-Book Exam

1–2 hours · \$0

- Completed Asbestos Open-Book Exam & Verification Form

Tip: Easy but CSLB cannot issue your license without it.

Step 6: File \$25,000 Contractor Bond

1–3 days · \$250–\$600/yr

■ **Bond is \$25K (not \$15K) since Jan 2023 — SB 607**

- \$25,000 surety bond certificate filed with CSLB
- \$25,000 BQI bond (if RME/RMO without 10%+ ownership)
- \$100,000 LLC bond (if applicable)

Tip: Premium is 1–5% of bond amount depending on credit score.

Step 7: Get Workers' Comp Insurance

1–3 days · \$800–\$3,000+/yr

■ **C-10 CANNOT exempt from WC — mandatory even solo**

- Certificate of Workers' Comp Insurance filed with CSLB

Tip: Ghost policies for no-employee contractors start ~\$800–1,500/yr.

Step 8: Pay License Fee

1–2 weeks · \$200

- \$200 payment (\$350 non-sole owner)
- All prior requirements completed

Tip: License # must appear on ALL ads, cards, contracts, vehicles. 32 hrs CE each 2-yr renewal.

Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost	When Due
CSLB application fee	\$450	With application
Live Scan fingerprinting	\$49–\$80	During processing
Exam prep course	\$150–\$500	Before exams
Contractor bond premium (annual)	\$250–\$600/yr	Before license issued
Workers' comp insurance (annual)	\$800–\$3,000+/yr	Before license issued
Initial license fee	\$200–\$350	After passing exams
TOTAL FIRST YEAR	\$900–\$2,000+	
Renewal (every 2 years)	\$450 + bond + WC	Before expiration

This checklist is for informational purposes only and is not legal advice. Verify all requirements at cslb.ca.gov before submitting your application. Bond amounts and fees are current as of March 2026.
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